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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 11, 2025 • \$4

D.C. crime returns to president's agenda

A new order would also focus on homelessness in city Trump often vilifies

BY SPENCER S. HSU
AND EMILY DAVIES

President Donald Trump is expected to issue an executive order that would seek to ratchet up penalties and enforcement of violent and petty crimes, clear homeless camps, and clean graffiti in the District of Columbia, according to three people briefed on the matter.

The directives targeting a city Trump has often vilified could come in an executive order as early as this week and emphasize public safety and beautification of Washington, according to the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss private conversations between the White House and the administration of D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D).

Details of the executive order may shift, but early drafts have included language that would order homeless encampments cleared, direct prosecutors to pursue tougher penalties for gun violence as well as petty crime such as public urination, and revive one of Trump's 2020 executive orders to protect national monuments, the people said. The order is also expected to focus broadly on federal parks controlled by the National Park Service.

SEE ORDER ON A8

Moves land Kennedy Center in turmoil

Trump names ally to unclear leadership role after firing half of board

BY TRAVIS M. ANDREWS,
MANUEL ROIG-FRANZIA
AND MATT VISER

President Donald Trump named former acting director of national intelligence Richard Grenell as the interim executive director of the Kennedy Center in a post on Truth Social, installing an ally at the head of one of the nation's premier cultural institutions, which Trump has vowed to overhaul.

The president's authority to unilaterally reshape the board, install new staff and make himself board chairman is an open question for the public-private institution.

"So we took over the Kennedy Center. We didn't like what they were showing and various other things," Trump told reporters in the Oval Office on Monday evening, adding, "But we have, I guess, a whole new group of people going in. . . . I'm going to be chairman of it, and we're going to make sure that it's good and it's not going to be woke."

Trump said Grenell, a former U.S. ambassador to Germany, would lead the organization "on a temporary basis." During the

SEE CENTER ON A8

Trump orders 25% tariffs on steel, aluminum



AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Workers hoist steel rebar with the help of a crane in Fuyang, China. The Asian nation produces more than half of the world's steel output.

Vance and Musk suggest ignoring court rulings

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

Federal judges have issued President Donald Trump stinging legal rebukes in the early clashes over his blitz of executive orders, and two of his top advisers have responded by suggesting that his administration defy the courts and move forward with its agenda.

There's no indication that Trump has adopted such a strategy, although a U.S. judge in Rhode Island ruled Monday that the administration has been violating a court order to disburse billions of dollars in already-approved grant funding and hint-

Rhetoric comes as judges issue sharp rebukes of executive actions

ed at possible penalties.

But the combative rhetoric by Vice President JD Vance and top adviser Elon Musk has troubled legal experts, who said there is no modern precedent for a president to ignore or defy court orders.

Vance wrote on X on Sunday that it would be illegal for a judge to tell a general how to conduct a military operation or for a jurist

to dictate how the attorney general used his discretion as a prosecutor. "Judges aren't allowed to control the executive's legitimate power," he wrote.

The vice president also shared a post by a Harvard University professor who argued that "judicial interference with legitimate acts of state" is a violation of the Constitution's separation of powers. Vance has made similar comments in the past, including on a 2021 podcast where he said he would urge the president to defy a court order preventing him from firing federal workers. On Monday, Vance continued to repost messages from other users

embracing the theme.

Musk, who owns X and is leading the Trump administration's effort to cut the federal government, echoed Vance's comments in his own postings on the social media platform. He called for impeaching a judge who last week temporarily blocked his associates from accessing sensitive data about Americans that is kept in a Treasury Department database.

SEE JUDGES ON A4

The Fix: The White House is laying the groundwork to defy orders. **A4**

Buyout breather: Resignation deadline is still on hold for now. **A9**

After tech layoffs, industry lost workers' trust

Plans to fire federal workers might mean the government sees the same unintended consequence

BY NAOMI NIX

For decades, Daelynn Moyer easily secured job offers in the tech industry, working her way up from a computer maintenance technician to a manager leading teams of engineers making software. A college dropout, she was confident tech work was her ticket to job security and she would stay in the industry until she retired.

Now, Moyer, 55, isn't so sure her future remains in tech. Since being laid off from Indeed last year, Moyer has applied to more than 140 jobs but received no offers. She and her wife are considering selling their house near Portland, Oregon, and buying land to farm instead — worried whatever job she finds won't cover her mortgage.

"It would be a meager existence, but it would be fulfilling," Moyer said. "I would no longer feel like a no longer useful commodity."

For years, people like Moyer flocked to Silicon Valley companies, lured by generous pay, benefits and the promise of tackling interesting problems at cutting-edge ventures. Companies showered employees with perks, from free meals and dry cleaning to niche wellness services. The seemingly unstoppable success of



WILL MATSUDA FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Daelynn Moyer, 55, worked for Indeed until being laid off last year and has not been able to find work in the industry.

major internet platforms like Meta, Google and Amazon made it seem that the industry was immune from the cyclic cutbacks that plague other sectors.

But since the tech industry slashed hundreds of thousands of jobs in mass layoffs spanning 2022 and 2023, the sector has shifted to routine cutbacks. On Monday, Meta slashed roughly 5 percent of its 74,067-member workforce, an effort to push out "low-performers."

Meta workers whose jobs had been cut started posting on social media platforms asking for referrals. Some expressed surprise at having been laid off despite receiving high ratings on performance reviews, others said they had received the notice while on parental leave. In a private Facebook group for ex-Meta employees, former co-workers welcomed the new additions to their group, according to copies of the messages viewed by The Washington Post.

One product manager who was laid off said he was told he was performing "at or above" expectations during a mid-year performance review. "I got zero signal that I was underperforming or at risk of being put on a performance improvement plan," said the worker, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to preserve his

SEE LAYOFFS ON A14

Farmers are out millions after USDA funds frozen

Growers paid up front for clean-energy systems, to improve infrastructure

BY DANIEL WU,
GAYA GUPTA
AND ANUMITA KAUR

Farmers report missing millions of dollars of funding they were promised by the U.S. Department of Agriculture, despite promises from the Trump administration that a federal funding freeze would not apply to projects directly benefiting individuals.

On his first day in office, President Donald Trump ordered the USDA to freeze funds for several programs designated by President Joe Biden's signature clean-energy and health-care law, the 2022 Inflation Reduction Act. The freeze paused some funding for the department's Environmental Quality Incentives Program, which helps farmers address natural resource concerns, and the Rural Energy for America Program.

SEE FARMERS ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Musk makes bid for OpenAI The tech entrepreneur and a group of investors offered \$97.4 billion, well below the company's valuation of \$157 billion. **A9**

Snowstorm on its way The Capital Weather Gang is predicting 3 to 6 inches to fall in the area, with more possible late Wednesday. **B1**

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Education Department staffers were put on leave for diversity courses they got under Trump. **A6**

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Elon Musk likes to communicate in memes. Being fluent in them could be key to understanding the Trump administration. **A12**
The White House dialed up its campaign against the CFPB as a union sued over halted agency operations. **A13**

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54124

